

HSE TOOLBOX TALK

WORKING AT HEIGHT

PURPOSE AND SCOPE

This Toolbox Talk aims to reduce the risk of falls, falling objects and fatal injuries during work at height. Its scope covers all tasks where a person could fall from one level to another and be injured — including platforms, scaffolds, ladders, roofs, floor openings and equipment surfaces. Controls follow the ISO 45001:2018 hierarchy of controls and are applied together with a permit to work, a risk assessment and a pre-task site check before work begins.

KEY HAZARDS

- Falls from unprotected edges, openings and working platforms.
- Walking on or falling through fragile surfaces and roofs.
- Incorrect use of ladders, scaffolds and access equipment.
- Tools, equipment and materials dropped to lower levels.
- MEWP overturn, entrapment or ejection from the basket.
- Adverse weather (wind, ice), slippery surfaces and poor lighting.
- Unapproved or inadequately rated anchor points.
- Suspension trauma after a fall and inadequate rescue provision.

CRITICAL CONTROL MEASURES (HIERARCHY OF CONTROLS)

1. AVOID (Elimination)

Avoid work at height where reasonably practicable. Prepare or pre-assemble the work at ground level, or use extendable / ground-operated equipment.

2. PREVENT FALLS (Collective protection)

Give priority to guardrails, working platforms, covers and barriers; use correctly erected scaffolds or a MEWP. Guardrail systems must be of adequate height and strength (OSHA: top rail ~1.07 m / 42 in).

3. MINIMISE CONSEQUENCES (Fall arrest)

Where collective protection is not practicable, use a safety net or a personal fall-arrest system: a full-body harness and an approved anchor ($\geq 5,000$ lb / ~ 22 kN per worker). Verify adequate fall clearance and swing-fall exposure.

4. ADMINISTRATIVE & PPE (Last resort)

Support controls with a permit to work, competent-person supervision, equipment inspection, a workable rescue plan and training. PPE alone is not adequate protection.

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CRITICAL WARNING



NEVER work at height without inspected, suitable fall protection. Fall protection is required at 1.8 m (6 ft) or more in construction and at 1.2 m (4 ft) or more in general industry. Even a fall from a low height can be fatal.

SITE CHECKLIST (BEFORE STARTING WORK)

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Permit to work and risk assessment approved | ☐ Safe access and guardrails complete |
| ☐ Scaffold / platform inspected and tagged | ☐ Anchor points identified and strength verified |
| ☐ Harness and lanyard inspected | ☐ Area below barricaded, tools tethered |
| ☐ Weather, surface and lighting suitable | ☐ Rescue plan and equipment ready |
| ☐ Personnel competent and briefed | |

STANDARDS AND REFERENCES

- OSHA 29 CFR 1926 Subpart M — Fall Protection (construction); 1.8 m (6 ft) trigger.
- OSHA 29 CFR 1910 Subpart D — Walking-Working Surfaces (general industry); 1.2 m (4 ft) trigger.
- ISO 45001:2018, Clause 8.1.2 — Hierarchy of Controls (Eliminate → Substitute → Engineering → Administrative → PPE).
- Aligned with IOSH and NEBOSH good-practice guidance.

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ATTENDANCE AND APPROVAL

Project / Site:

Date:

Presented by:

Work area:

No	Full Name	Company / Role	Signature
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